IOWA

The Hawkeye State



Iowa did not become America's breadbasket by accident. It was built—methodically, stubbornly, season by season—by the hands of immigrant farmers who arrived in the mid-1800s and looked at the rolling prairie and saw not wilderness, but possibility. Among the first and most numerous were German and Czech settlers who pushed into eastern and central Iowa, staking claims in counties like Linn, Benton, and Johnson, breaking the deep black soil that would prove to be some of the most fertile farmland on earth. They brought with them their language, their faith, their work ethic, and perhaps most importantly, their food.

For these families, nothing was wasted. The hog was central to farm life-raised on corn, slaughtered in the cold months of late autumn, and preserved with the kind of practical ingenuity that defines frontier cooking. Every cut had a purpose. Hams were smoked and cured in the farmhouse smokehouse. Scraps and trimmings were ground, seasoned, and stretched into something new. From this tradition of thrift and resourcefulness, the ham ball was born—a dish that managed to be both humble and deeply satisfying, the kind of food that fed a farm family through a hard Iowa winter without apology.

The women who developed and refined this dish deserve their place in culinary history, even if their names rarely made it into print. In church basements from Cedar Rapids to Des Moines, in Grange halls and community suppers across the Iowa countryside, these cooks—many of them first and second-generation immigrants—fed their communities from long tables covered in checkered cloth. Ham balls, braised low and slow in a sweet and tangy sauce of brown sugar, vinegar, and mustard, appeared at nearly every gathering. The sauce was a revelation—it transformed the salty, smoky ground ham into something caramelized and complex, sticky at the edges and tender at the center, filling a room with a smell that made it impossible to wait for supper.

By the early 20th century, ham balls had moved from farmhouse necessity to beloved tradition. They appeared in the spiral-bound community cookbooks that Iowa church groups and women's auxiliaries produced by the thousands—the kind of cookbooks held together with love and cooking grease, passed down through families like heirlooms. Iowa's meatpacking industry, centered in cities like Ottumwa and Sioux City, kept pork abundant and affordable, ensuring that ham remained a fixture on the Iowa table long after the frontier had closed and the farms had modernized.

What makes ham balls remarkable is how effortlessly they reward the cook. The ingredients are straightforward, the technique forgiving, and the result is the kind of dish that earns recipe requests before the plates are even cleared. Whether served at a holiday table, a potluck supper, or a quiet Sunday dinner, they carry with them the warmth of every Iowa kitchen they've ever come out of. Make them once, and you'll understand immediately why generations of Iowa families refused to let this recipe leave the family. Make them for a crowd, and watch them disappear.

HAM BALLS WITH SWEET SAUCE

Frontier German and Czech settlers stretched every scrap of the hog into ham balls, braised in a sweet-tangy sauce that became a fixture of Iowa church suppers.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1 ½ lb. ground ham (can grind leftover ham or buy ground ham)
- 1 lb. ground pork
- 1 cup graham cracker, crushed (about 8 full crackers)
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup milk

SAUCE

- 1 cup brown sugar
- ¾ cup ketchup
- 1 Tbsp yellow mustard (optional, for tang)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat*: Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C).
2. *Mix the ham balls*: In a large bowl, combine the ground ham, ground pork, crushed graham cracker, eggs, and milk. Mix until just combined—don't overwork the meat. Form into balls (about the size of a golf ball; you'll get around 18–24 balls).
3. *Arrange in a baking dish*: Place the ham balls in a single layer in a large baking dish (you can grease it lightly if desired).
4. *Prepare the sauce*: In a medium bowl, whisk together the brown sugar, ketchup, and mustard until smooth. Pour the sauce evenly over the ham balls.
5. *Bake*: Cover loosely with foil and bake for 45 minutes. Uncover and bake for an additional 15–20 minutes, basting occasionally, until the sauce is bubbling and slightly caramelized.

